

Soloviev's \$400 Rent Ask Tests Whether Manhattan Office Has a Ceiling or Just a Price

A \$400 psf target at 9 West 57th Street signals that top-tier office is repricing, but the bid depth remains narrow.

The most interesting number in Stefan Soloviev's \$400 per square foot rent ask is not the rent itself. It is the square footage: 11,155. That is not a floor plate. It is a trophy suite inside a building that has spent decades cultivating scarcity as a business model.

Soloviev is marketing the last two spaces at 9 West 57th Street, a 1.5 million-square-foot tower that his father Sheldon Solow famously kept partially empty rather than lease to the wrong tenant. The strategy was eccentric. It was also economically rational. By restricting supply, Solow created a premium that no amount of new construction could replicate. His son is now testing whether that premium has a new ceiling.

The \$400 target would shatter the building's own record of \$327 per square foot, set in April on a 5,000-square-foot lease. That deal itself topped SL Green's One Vanderbilt, which had held the Manhattan high-water mark at roughly \$305 per square foot in 2022. The progression is clear: top-of-market rents are rising, but only for the smallest, most curated spaces in the most exclusive towers. This is not a broad office recovery.

It is a scarcity premium concentrated in a handful of buildings where the landlord controls supply, the views are irreplaceable, and the tenant is buying status as much as square footage. The capital markets signal is subtler but more important: the bid for top-tier office is deepening, but the bid depth is still measured in thousands of square feet, not hundreds of thousands.

JLL's data shows Manhattan recorded 313 leases at \$100 per square foot or more in 2025, up from 212 in 2024. Deals above \$200 reached 28, including six above \$250. The volume is growing, but the base is still narrow. A \$400 lease would be an outlier even within that cohort.

It would also be a data point that lenders and investors will use to underwrite the top end of the office market, where valuation depends on rent growth that has been absent for most buildings. For owners with maturities approaching, the Soloviev strategy is instructive but not replicable. Most office landlords cannot hold space empty while waiting for the perfect tenant. They face debt service, leasing commissions, and capital improvement deadlines.

Soloviev has the balance sheet to wait. His family office controls the building free of the institutional debt that forces other owners to lease at any price. That optionality is the real asset. The tenants signing at \$300-plus are not a broad cross-section of the economy. They are family offices, private equity firms, and asset managers who treat rent as a cost of talent retention and client perception.

Webster, the family office for the founder of agricultural trading firm SFI, took 5,000 square feet at \$315. Infinedi Partners, Continuum, and Halle Capital Management signed in the \$200 range. These are not law firms or banks making marginal space decisions. They are capital allocators making a statement. What should the market watch next? Not whether Soloviev gets \$400. That is a marketing target.

What matters is whether the next tier of buildings can push past \$200 with any consistency. If the spread between the top 1% of office space and the rest continues to widen, the valuation gap will follow. Lenders underwriting office loans will need to decide whether to finance scarcity or cash flow. Those are not the same thing. The deal is not proof that Manhattan office is back.

It is proof that the market for the best space in the best building with the most patient owner has its own gravity. Everyone else is still waiting for the bid to arrive.

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